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How the 'Attention Economy' of Web 2.0 failed us, and the promise Web 3.0 holds.



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Web 2.0's 'Attention Economy' gave us all anxiety. But Web 3.0 is here to make things better.

In the few seconds it took to read that headline, more than 6,000 tweets were tweeted on Twitter, a few dozen videos were uploaded on YouTube, more than a thousand curated photos were published on Instagram, and nearly 30,000 pieces of new content were posted on Facebook.

To say that we are drowning in content is an understatement. In 2013, almost a decade ago, Europe-based research agency SINTEF said that more than 90% of all the data in the world was generated in the previous two years.

And around 150 years from now, the number of digital bits will reach an unimaginable value, “exceeding the number of all atoms on Earth”, says Melvin Vopson, senior lecturer in Physics at the University of Portsmouth.

But no one has the time, energy, mental space, or attention to consume it all. Brands, agencies, advertisers, and social media platforms recognize this. And they're all fighting to get a piece of our attention no matter how small.

And with the continued growth of the internet, this demand for our limited attention will only become greater. We're free to place the blame on social networks, advertisers, and all the other applications Web 2.0 gave us that we initially welcomed with arms outflung.

But now this excess in information and deficit in attention has been affecting us in a multitude of ways we're still not completely aware of. But with the coming of Web 3.0, we may just take our attention back.

How did we end up in the attention economy?

It was in 1971, twelve years before the internet was “born” that economist, and Nobel Laureate Herbert Simon formally proposed the “attention economy.” He called attention the “bottleneck of human thought” that restricts what we can perceive around us.

Unlike other sources of value humankind has cherished in the past — land, labor, information — it is attention that is now truly scarce. This attention, “is the hard currency of cyberspace.”

And of the total amount of it available per person, it’s becoming more and more limited. Attention, says Michael Goldhaber, will not only predict where money will be directed to, he goes as far as saying that it could replace money altogether. Now everyone is fighting for it.

Why is Web 2.0 to blame for the attention economy?

Today’s attention economy, says Vitaly Gerko, belongs to Web 2.0, the iteration of the internet that gave everyone the freedom and license to create and share whatever was on their mind.

It gave people the capacity to participate in the content creation process through the creation of web-based communities and applications such as social networking sites, blogs, forums, and wikis.

Now, says Gerko, power belongs to huge tech corporations, like Meta, Alphabet, Amazon, TikTok, Apple, and Twitter, as they create “walled gardens, or closed-off ecosystems that keep user data and are run without any external interference and regulation.” And for these companies, our attention is their most valuable asset.

These company's algorithms have long been bemoaned by consumers and lawmakers in the last decade because of their design to ingeniously keep our attention for as long as possible, almost to the point of manipulation.

They show us the funniest, most sexy, moving, insulting, and entertaining pieces of content available within our social network to lure us even deeper. The more extreme the better, because extreme levels of emotion keep our attention the longest.

There have been many studies on how people's continued exposure to media affects their perception of the world. In fact, George Gerbner's Cultivation Theory proposed in the 1960s still applies to this day.

He said that high frequency consumers of media — television, at the time of the study — are more susceptible to media messages and the belief that they are real and valid.

Which explains why millions of people are of the belief that the world is flat or that climate change is a capitalist hoax. Similarly, this also explains why it seems everyone around us is getting married or having kids — we've just been disproportionately exposed to these pieces of content.

Good news for narcissists, bad news for us

The attention economy does spell good news for those who like to share everything about themselves. Whether it's a deeply personal video about why they decided to break up with their partner, or the most mundane supermarket run, anything can be content, and anything can get people's attention.



Photo by Austin Distel on Unsplash

And that's probably why many of us perceive that people are becoming more and more shallow and self-absorbed, when most similarly empty content has simply been directed at us.

Web 2.0 also made everyone an aspiring citizen journalist. Armed with a laptop, smartphone, and a mobile connection, everyone is a mobile newsroom — but without the journalism standards. Meanwhile, in order to compete, legitimate publications and news organizations have had no choice but to turn to sensationalism.

All this information constantly pulls our attention in different directions, making it so thin that we can't retain anything significant from each experience anymore.

We've mistakenly praised the capacity of people to multi-task. But in the face of the attention economy, what's more impressive is the ability to focus.

According to Mark Manson, focus — not multitasking — brings long-term success. When we focus on a person, we develop relationships. When we focus on a task, we establish quality. But when the abundance of information takes that focus away, we're left with just shallow understanding.

When a society focuses on trying to achieve many things, the result, says Korean-born German philosopher Byung-Chul Han, is hyperattention. It's a broad but flat mode of attention that scatters our focus and prevents us from achieving an immersion that is contemplative almost.

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Some people may call it “being in the zone” or “the flow state,” but whatever it is, it helps us develop our capacity for structured thought and analysis, and brings forth a far superior outcome. Instead, Web 2.0 took everything we gave it and, in return, gave us social anxiety, self-esteem issues, and a few beautiful recipe videos. But not anymore.

Can the more decentralised Web 3.0 make things better?

More and more consumers are now becoming aware of these issues and the dangers that the attention economy presents — with thanks to the publication of stories such as the Facebook–Cambridge Analytica data scandal that brought to light the unethical collection and use of user data, or

the 2020 Netflix film *The Social Dilemma* that managed to present how these social networks exploit its users to hold their attention.

A shift is happening. The incentive structure of Web 2.0 — built around the users as the product, where corporations own and manage their data, and users' sentiment had little power in the way a platform is run — is about to see a change.

The new iteration of the internet, Web 3.0, now seeks to align the incentive between the platform and its users by making them stakeholders. They now have a say on how things are managed, and instead of being exploited as the end product, they have become equal creators and co-owners.

And with the continued shift, it's the hope of millions that our attention will be ours to control once again. In 2021, Doug Petkanics went so far as to proclaim that “Web 3.0 can repair the attention-driven digital economy.” While that still remains to be seen, we can already glimpse rays of hope through the cracks.

This is possible because with a more decentralized internet, platforms and its users are no longer centered around corporations that collect and make money from user data. Because the structure or the “code,” of the platform is spread everywhere and not in one private server, anyone with the skills and capability can contribute to it and essentially improve upon it to serve everyone better.

And isn't it the case that when individuals contribute their time and effort to something of importance to them, they become more invested in the growth and success of that venture? In Web 3.0, it isn't just that anyone can innovate, but that anyone can be a part of that innovation.

Because Web 3.0 applications are based on blockchain, they will allow peer-to-peer transactions between users, and these transactions are transparent and visible to anyone. Gone are the imbalanced creator economics of Web 2.0. By democratizing access and removing the distinction between creators and fans, everyone has the chance to learn from and grow with the platform — not be manipulated by it.

Because of decentralization, users, not corporations, will now own their data in Web 3.0. All their information will be stored in many independent servers at the same time, spreading out the power that was once monopolized by large companies.

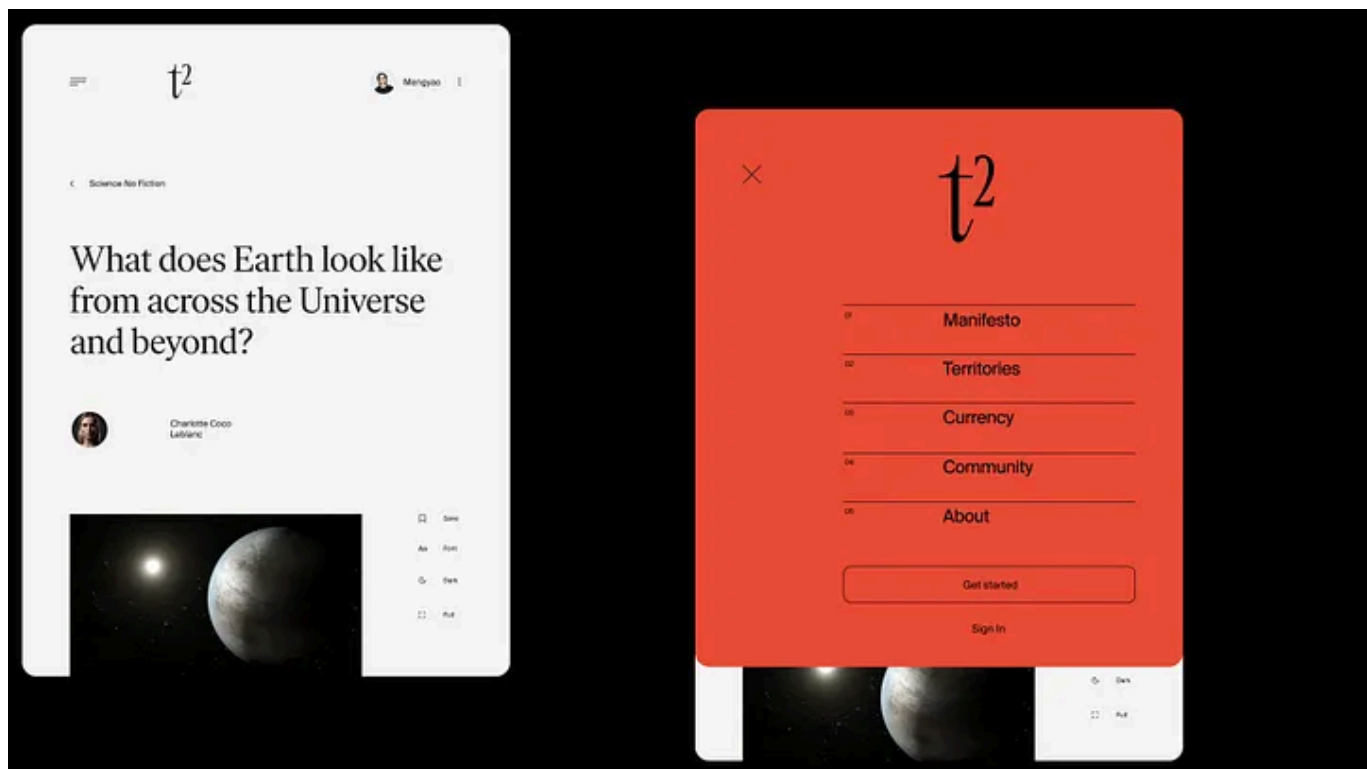
For Petkanics, this isn't just a win for privacy. For him, the gains can actually result in the protection of user value which, in turn, can become a competitive advantage for those who dare do it correctly.

Now, users can control who sees their data and what's done with it. At the same time, they will have a say in what happens to it. They can choose to monetize it or not. And the revenue will go to the users, not companies.

Because of all these, transparency will also be a dominant feature where consumers can see and understand how the information they are about to consume was made, who's behind it, and based on these, make informed choices.

It's time to take back our attention with decentralised publishing

How then does one with the most coveted attention use this valuable asset? As you would with any scarce resource — water, gold, time — you need to properly manage its use. In the case of attention, you need focus. And that's exactly what the decentralized online publisher t2 hopes to help its users do.



Using Web 3.0 technologies, t2 allows users to own the content and its curation. At the same time, it empowers users to take ownership of their attention by providing fair incentives, aligned between readers, writers, and the platform's curators in a peer-to-peer manner using blockchain.

The incentive of the t2 platform isn't to make money from users' attention, but to align with them to find the most relevant content for everyone. And because of this, they hope to establish a more democratic and open-minded curation process.

The content on the platform is curated by real people, not algorithms. The community determines the experience the users will have to make reading more social.

The result is a revolutionary social media platform that earns those two descriptive adjectives: genuinely social as it provides a real community for users to be engage with others, be recognized, and rewarded for their

efforts; but also a *media* platform that provides thoughtful content worthy of attention.

For founder Mengyao Han, they are incentivizing deep reading. And in the process, they capture these passive contributions and use it to shape the platform's content. This breaks the old digital economy, and for the first time on any publishing platform, recognises the reader's effort.

And as a decentralized online publisher, data is not owned but shared, allowing everyone to participate and collaborate by using all available information in a decentralised way.

Taking back our attention and giving it to those who deserve it

The beauty of a scarce economic resource like attention is that unlike water, oil, or land, the only thing that affects its status is our decision on where and how to use it.

So when Mandel and Van der Leun called attention “the hard currency of cyberspace,” it perhaps didn't cross their mind that as currency, it could also be spread out, decentralised, and made more transparent — everything Web 3.0 hopes to give us.

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Written by Peter Imbong, content creator at t2.world.

Special thanks to our community member Siebold, who recommended The Burnout Society by Byung-Chul Han to us. What a good read.

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About T2

T2 is a decentralised publisher curated by communities. It is a world of narratives where your attention nurtures creators and subcultures and helps them grow. T2 restores the balanced relationships between readers, writers, and communities, making us more connected through what we love. On t2, time is value and manifests subcultures.

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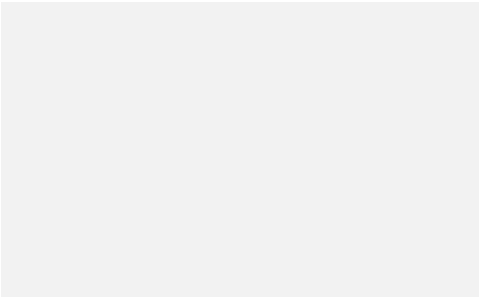
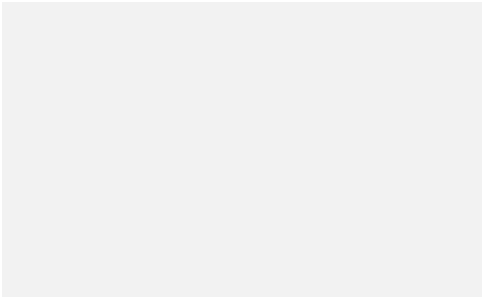
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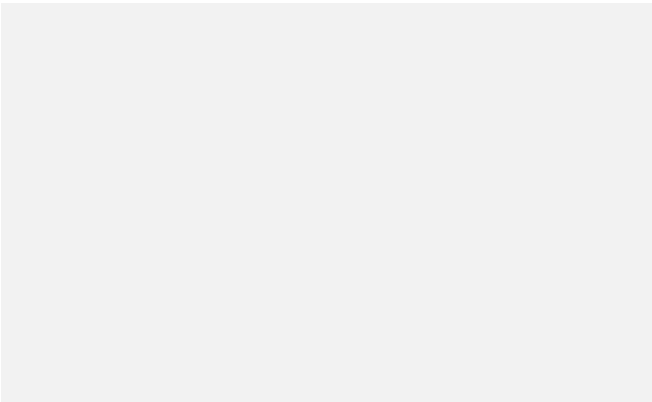
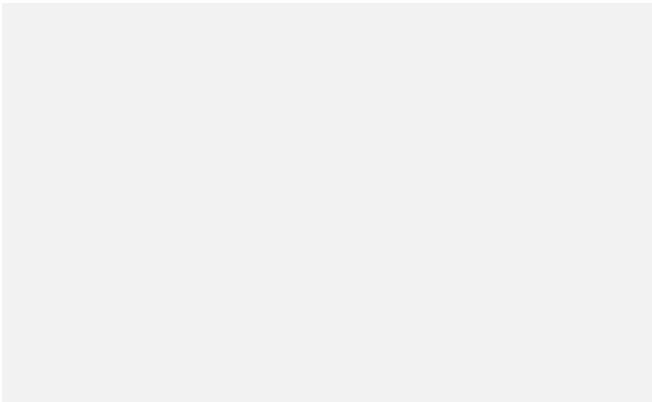
At t2 (time²), we are building a transparent, decentralized, and collaborative social network around reading and writing.

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